

activity on the internet with iPhone mock-ups by some talented (and other not so talented) Photoshoppers cropping up everywhere and every Apple rumour site going crazy with proposed specifications and features. This year, however, it became a huge wave unrivalled by anything that has preceded it. It seeped out of the world of Apple fanatics to the general news websites concerning technology. Almost everyday, there used to be an iPhone related story on the front page of digg. And all this for a device that Apple had not even hinted at. People had started expecting that Apple would not launch a phone just to shock the world.

Apple has a great culture of secrecy about anything they do. Therefore, even the slightest hint of any patent filings or leaks draws a lot of media attention. Apple used this as a leverage to throw the rumour-mongers off course. They filed several fake patents with imaginary features and fantastic diagrams. There was this diagram of an enclosure strongly resembling the iPod Mini and people all over the Internet were suddenly blaspheming the iPhone over its atrocious design. Then there was this patent for a screen that was described in such an outlandish way that it was difficult to imagine what it could actually be like. No one had expected the multi-touch screen, but it is quite clear now what that patent was for.

Fans of Apple have been lusting for a mobile phone for a long time and this time, they were really expecting Apple to deliver on their hopes. The Internet was suddenly flooded with Photoshopped images of what the iPhone would be like. It is quite fun to browse through some of these images. Phones of every conceivable shape, size and form emerged in these mock-ups. There were candybar phones, flip phones, sliders, swivel phones, wearable phones, and just plain weird, imaginary, fantasy devices. Some of these concepts were blatant rip-offs of existing design, with the Motorola RAZR phone showing up in various colours and an Apple logo very often.

Then came the shocker when Cisco released their new range of VoIP phones in December, 2006 that were branded “iPhones.”